



PATH 14

A small AI membership

The vault must stay useful if they never attend a call.

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Who this is for

You can show up monthly with updated workflows after the one-time product has sold.

First sale

Three members who stay past month one.

Time to first

After you have buyers

Cash window

\$9-\$19/month

Tools

Leave this alone

Stripe subscriptions or Stan, a simple member page, dated file names, a calendar reminder for the monthly note.

A \$99/month room with nothing inside. Launching this before the one-time product has sold.

What this actually is

The definition

A small membership is a vault that stays useful if they never attend a call. That sentence is the whole design. Updates. New templates. A monthly workflow when the models change. Not your personality, unless you can keep that promise on a tired Thursday in February.

Members already bought the one-time file — the playbook, the prompt stack, the template pack — and the tools moved. A setting changed. A prompt that used to work got mushy. The membership is the living layer on top of a product that already earned trust.

This is a second product. It is not a way to avoid finishing the first one. A \$99 room with a Discord and a promise is a leak. A \$9 vault with three real files and a cancel button that works is a quiet till.

Cancel anytime. Earn the next month. Those two rules keep you honest. Live is optional garnish. The vault is the meal. Price sits in a band a person can keep without a meeting with themselves: \$9–\$19 a month.

What this is not

This is not a community. Ten quiet downloaders beat a hundred lurkers in a dead chat. If you want a group, that is a different path.

This is not a mastermind. There is no inner circle, no \$99 energy, no fake countdown on an infinite folder.

This is not a way to hide the one-time file so the only door is a card on file. People who only want the file should still be able to buy it and leave.

This is not custom work at \$9. A member who wants captions written for their shop is a productized job, not a vault member.

Why this works now

The tools move. Models shift. A prompt that shipped in March gets mushy in August. Buyers already email did this still work after the update. You are answering that for free in a messy inbox, forever, or you put the answer in a dated file and charge \$9 for the living layer.

A person who already paid \$19–\$47 for your file can keep \$9 without a story. They are not shopping for a new guru. They are shopping for the version that still runs.

Cancel that works is part of why it works. Subscription fatigue is real. Easy cancel is how a serious \$9 survives next to a pile of \$29 rooms people resent.

Three anti-patterns

Anti-pattern one: launching this before the one-time product has sold. You will pitch strangers a living layer on a book they never bought. No context, no trust, no honest invite list.

Anti-pattern two: a \$99 room with nothing inside. High price does not create value. It creates refunds and a room you dread. Earn \$9 first. Raise when the archive is fat.

Anti-pattern three: making calls the product. They will miss the call. You will miss the call. The vault should have been enough. If attendance is the only way to get the value, you built a calendar, not a membership.

The deal you keep

You keep the vault useful. You keep cancel easy. You keep selling the one-time file. You do not keep a guilt form, a fake scarcity counter, custom work inside \$9, or a silent charge after you vanish. If those stay clean, three people will still be there on day 45. That is the first real sale of this path.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This fits you if

This path fits if you already have buyers of a one-time file and you can name, in one sentence, what those buyers still need after they finish the PDF. It fits if you already update your own workflows when the tools move, and writing that down would take a morning, not a new personality.

It also fits if you can stand a monthly rhythm: a dated note, a new file, a short list of what changed. If you vanish for eight weeks, you should already have decided how you refund the unused month.

It fits if people already email you the same question twice. That repeated question is next month's file. You are holding the membership in your inbox.

Skip this if

Skip it if the one-time product has not sold. Skip it if you want a membership so you do not have to ship a finished file. Skip it if the only offer is community and a chat that goes quiet at 4pm. Skip it if they must attend a call for the thing to be worth \$9. They will not attend. They will still want the file.

Skip the \$99 version until people already stay at \$9. High price does not create value. It creates refunds and a room you dread.

Skip it if you hate writing a monthly note. A quarterly bundle sold as a one-time update pack is allowed. Recurring billing is a promise. Do not make it if you will resent it in February.

The honest middle

If the file is selling and you already send update emails for free, you are running a membership at \$0. Put the cancel button on it and charge \$9. That is the whole move.

If the file is not selling, go sell the file. This path does not start in week 1 of your business. It starts after you have buyers.

If you can keep a folder but you cannot keep a Zoom, do not list a Zoom. Avery knew February would be tired. No calls on the page. That was the honest middle, and it worked.

Skills and time

Skills: name the gap the PDF cannot cover, ship three files before anyone is charged, write a monthly note with two headings, decline custom work inside \$9, test cancel from a second email, refund without a speech if you vanish.

Time: a morning to open the vault. Two hours on the first Tuesday of each month to rerun the workflow and write the note. Replies in a 48-hour weekday window. Not a second job. Not a Discord you check at 11pm.

If two hours a month feels impossible, do not open it. The charge will continue. The vault will not.

Two-minute self-test

Answer yes or no. No essays.

Has the one-time file sold to people who are not me?

Can I name what members get that the file does not, in one sentence?

Can I put three real files in a folder this week, named by job and date?

Will I write a monthly note on a tired Thursday in February?

Will I let them cancel in two clicks without a guilt form?

Four or five yeses: build the vault this week, invite buyers only. Three: you may be one file sale away; go sell the file. Two or fewer: skip this path. A quarterly paid update pack is allowed instead.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this in before you open a platform

Write this on a card: \$9 a month for the updates the [book / stack / template] does not get. New workflow when the tools change. Cancel anytime. If you cannot say what the updates are, you do not have an offer.

The brackets are the product. Book, stack, or template they already bought. Updates are dated workflows, new templates, the monthly note. Cancel anytime is on the page, not in your head.

Five sentences that work

\$9 a month for updates the landscaping content playbook does not get. New workflow when the tools change. Cancel anytime.

\$9 a month for the dated prompt stack when the model gets mushy. New checklist each month. Cancel anytime.

\$9 a month for seasonal templates the \$27 file never had. Winter, spring, tax, back-to-school. Cancel anytime.

\$19 a month for the back catalog: six months of workflows plus the new one. Cancel anytime. Grandfather the first members at \$9.

\$9 a month for the client-follow-up workflow, rewritten when the tools move. Three files in the vault on day one. Cancel anytime.

If the sentence is about your energy, your space, or your community, start again with files.

What they get that the file does not

The dated workflow for this month's model behavior — what broke, what you changed, the prompt or SOP that replaces last quarter's version.

New templates or checklists that did not exist when they bought the file.

A short archive they can search on a Sunday, not a chat scroll.

Optional: a monthly office-hours slot if you can keep it when you are tired. If you cannot, do not list it.

A vanish rule: if you go quiet for 30 days without a note, they get the unused month back.

What they do not get

Not a second brain on Slack. Not custom work inside the \$9. Not you hiding the one-time product so the only door is a subscription. The file stays for sale. People who only want the file

should still be able to buy it and leave. Not a Discord they have to live in. Not a call they have to attend. Not an inner circle.

Packaging

One member page. What they get. What they do not. Price \$9. Cancel anytime. Vanish/refund rule. Three files listed by name, date, and job, already in the folder. Checkout line: \$9/month for updates the book does not get. Three files in the vault on day one. Cancel anytime. If I vanish, you get the unused month back.

Invite existing buyers first, with a true sentence. Public listing only after buyers have joined. The original file stays on the site with one line pointing at the vault as a second product, not a replacement.

What done looks like

The definition

Done for launch is not a hundred members. Done is:

- The one-time file has sold to real buyers.

- You wrote what members get that the book does not.

- Three items are in the vault before anyone is charged. Not coming soon.

- Price is \$9–\$19. Checkout works. Cancel is one or two clicks, not a guilt form.

- You invited existing buyers first, with a true sentence.

Done for the first season is three members who stay past month one. Ten people who cancel on day 28 means the vault was a teaser. Three people still there on day 45 means you earned the second month.

A month is done when the note went out: what changed in the tools, what file you added, where it lives. If you hosted a call, a recording or the written version is in the vault within 48 hours. If you did not host a call, the vault still got the file. The call was never the product.

Fairness test

Open the vault as a member would, on a Sunday, with no Zoom on the calendar. Can they run something this month? If no, you are charging for a room. Would you keep \$9 of this if you were them and you never liked calls? If the honest answer is I would cancel, add the file now, not on day 31 after they leave.

Technical done

Three vault items live, named YYYY-MM-job, not Update!!

A two-line index: file, date, job.

Stripe or Stan subscription, one product, one price.

Cancel tested from a second email. Two clicks.

Vanish/refund rule on the page.

Invites sent to existing buyers, not a public circus.

Monthly note on a calendar, same week, same two headings.

The one-time file still for sale.

Not-done-yet list

File has not sold.

Vault is a roadmap.

Welcome video promising the files.

Cancel takes a support ticket.

Discord is the product and it is quiet.

Calls listed, vault empty if they miss one.

\$99 for three PDFs and a smile.

Public launch to strangers with no invite list.

Custom captions being delivered inside \$9.

Monthly note skipped, charge still ran, no refund offered.

Fake 12 spots left on an infinite folder.

Pricing and the cash window

The range

\$9–\$19 a month. \$9 is the default. \$19 is for a vault that already has a back catalog — six months of workflows, not three PDFs and a smile.

A person who already paid \$19–\$47 for your file can keep \$9 without a story. \$29 starts to feel like another product they have to justify. \$99 is a different business: more support, more presence, more ways to fail them. Do not collect \$99 for a Discord you check twice a week.

Annual can wait. If you offer it, 10 months for the price of 12 is plenty — \$90 for the year at the \$9 level. Do not discount monthly to fill seats. There are no seats. There is a vault.

When to raise

Raise for new members when the archive is fat: six-plus dated workflows, not three files and a hope. Grandfather the first ones at \$9. Do not raise to make up for churn. Churn means the vault did not earn the second month. Fix the files.

Do not start at \$19 to look serious. Serious is three files and a cancel button. \$19 from day one is allowed only if the back catalog already exists. Otherwise \$9.

Refunds in one sentence

Cancel anytime, unused month refunded if you vanish for 30 days with no note and no file; mistaken joins refunded once without a speech; custom-work seekers refunded and pointed at a package. You do not refund a month they had access to files they did not open.

Never charge for these

Never charge \$99 for an empty room. Never charge for a Discord that is the product. Never charge a setup fee on top of \$9. Never charge extra to cancel. Never hide the one-time file so the

subscription is the only door. Never keep charging after you skipped the note and added no file. Never charge for custom captions inside the membership.

Worked dollars

Three members at \$9 is \$27 a month. That is a signal, not rent. Ten is \$90. Thirty is \$270, which starts to pay for the morning you spend on the note. Avery in month 4: fourteen members, about \$126 a month. Enough to pay for the morning and to stop giving updates away in a messy inbox.

The cash window opens after you have buyers. Charge on the same date. Send the update in the same week. If you cannot support more people, cap it. Scarcity should be your calendar, not a fake 3 spots left on a folder.

Avery's first week: five joined, one canceled on day 6 (wanted custom captions, refunded, pointed at a productized service). By day 45, three still there. That matched the first-sale line. The \$27 playbook stayed on the site. New buyers are the only honest top of funnel.

The first 72 hours

Do not spend 72 hours touring community platforms. Spend it on the vault and the sentence.

Day 1 morning

Open the one-time file. List what it cannot do after a model change. List questions buyers already asked. Circle three items you can finish this week: a revised prompt, a new checklist, a one-page what broke in [month] workflow. Those three are the vault.

Write the offer sentence on a card. \$9 a month for the updates the [file] does not get. Cancel anytime. If you cannot fill the file name, stop. You do not have a first product.

Day 1 afternoon

One member page. What they get. What they do not. Price \$9. Cancel anytime. Refund the unused month if you vanish — write that down. Stripe or Stan. Do not tour five community tools. The dumbest tool you will keep beats the pretty one you will abandon.

Name the three files like jobs: 2026-08-workflow-client-follow-up, not Update!!. Start the first of the three if it is not already written.

Day 1 night

Buy the membership from a second email. Cancel it. If cancel takes a support ticket, you built a trap. Fix the trap before anyone else pays. Then stop decorating the page.

Day 2

Finish all three vault items. A two-line index: file, date, job. Put them in the folder a member will actually open. No welcome video promising a roadmap. No Discord. No countdown.

Draft ten invite notes to people who already paid. Personal. Not a blast with merge tags you have not checked. Name the most useful of the three files in the note.

Day 3

Send the ten invites. Not a public launch. The book stays as it is; this is the living layer; \$9; cancel anytime; here are the three files. Point joins at the three files, not at a future call.

If someone asks for custom, decline inside the membership and name the other path. If someone joins by mistake, refund. Do not chase.

By hour 72 you have: gap list, \$9, working cancel, three vault items with job-shaped names, invites to existing buyers only. You do not have a community. You do not have a hundred members. You have a vault a Sunday downloader can use tonight.

The path, step by step

The twelve-plus moves

Sell the one-time file first. Membership is a second product for people who already trust you. If path 1 has not sold, go back. A vault with no buyers is a folder you will resent. The file is how new members appear later, too. Keep selling it forever.

Write what members get that the book does not. Dated workflows, new templates, the monthly note. If the paragraph is about your energy or your space, start again with files. Put the sentence on the member page. If you cannot say it in one breath, you do not have an offer.

Vault first, calls optional. Build the folder as if nobody will ever attend a Zoom. If you add a call later, the recap lands in the vault within two days. If you are tired, skip the call and write the file. Never make attendance the only way to get the value.

Three items in the vault before the door opens. Not a roadmap. Not a welcome video promising the roadmap. Three files they can use tonight. Named by job and date. Indexed. If you only have two, you are not open. Finish the third this week.

Price \$9–\$19 and make cancel easy. Test it yourself from a second email. Write the vanish/refund rule on the page so you are stuck with your own standard. If cancel takes a ticket, you built a trap. \$9 is the default. \$19 waits for a fat archive.

Invite existing buyers first. Ten personal notes. Public launch only after three people have stayed, or at least paid without asking wait, what is this. A public circus to strangers is how you collect day-7 cancels and a reputation for empty rooms.

A monthly note with two headings. What changed in the tools. What file you added. Date it. Under a page. Miss it twice and you are running a ghost charge. Same week every month. Avery used the first Tuesday and two hours. Steal that.

Answer in the vault, not in private exception. A good question becomes a file everyone gets. Custom work belongs in a paid project, not inside \$9. If you answer one person in a long private thread, you just trained them that \$9 buys a junior employee.

Cap when your calendar says so. If you cannot read the replies or you are slipping the note, close new signups. A fake counter is a trick. A real cap is a number you can host. For a folder-only vault the number can be high. For a vault plus replies it might be 30.

Keep selling the one-time file. Do not hide it to milk the subscription. The file is how new members appear. Mention the vault once after they have the file, not as a popup on page one.

Earn month two on purpose. At day 20, look at the vault as a member would. Is there a reason to stay besides inertia? If not, add the file now, not on day 31 after they cancel. Inertia is not a

business. The second charge is the product working.

Review stay-rate at day 45. Three members still there is a working path. A pile of day-7 cancels means the listing overpromised. Fix the files. Do not raise the price to make up for churn. Do not invent a community to paper over an empty folder.

Keep a running log of tool changes. Model updates, UI moves, a setting that used to be default. The monthly note writes itself from that log. If you abandoned the job the file teaches, the vault will rot. Run the system yourself or close the door.

Decline the live critique inside \$9. Offer a one-time package at the freelance rate. Put the reusable part of their question in next month's file. The vault stays a vault. Avery did this in month 4 and kept fourteen members without becoming a junior employee.

A worked example: Avery's \$9 vault

Who

Avery sold a \$27 playbook: a 10-day content system for one-person landscaping companies. Forty-ish buyers. Then the model started ignoring the keep it local, no corporate voice constraint. Buyers emailed. Avery answered the same reply for free, forever. No following worth mentioning. A file that had already earned trust. That is the only honest start.

Calendar

Week 0: confirmed the file had sold. Listed the inbox questions. Circled three items.

Week 1, Monday: offer sentence on a card. \$9/month for updates the book does not get. Cancel anytime. Member page on Stan. Cancel tested from a second email. Vanish rule written.

Week 1, Tuesday–Wednesday: three vault items finished. (1) the revised prompt stack tested that week, (2) a one-page what changed in the tools this month note, (3) a seasonal winter checklist the original file never had. Named by month and job. Two-line index.

Week 1, Thursday: twelve invite notes to existing buyers only. No Discord. No calls on the page. Avery knew February would be tired.

Week 1, Friday: five joined. One asked for a live critique in the first email. Avery said no inside the \$9.

The shipped artifact

The vault on day one: three files a landscaper could run that night. The revised prompt stack with the local-voice constraint restated in blunt lines. The dated what-changed note naming the mushy behavior. The winter checklist the \$27 file never had. No video. No chat. A folder.

Later artifact: six monthly workflows, two extra checklists, the first-Tuesday note every month. The \$27 file still on the site.

The mistake

Avery almost listed a monthly Zoom because it felt more like a real membership. Almost opened a Discord. Almost hid the \$27 file so people would have to join to get the new stack. Caught all three. Smaller miss: one of the twelve notes sounded like a launch, not a living layer. That buyer asked wait, did I already pay for this? Avery answered with the truth: the file is the job as of a date; the vault is the continuation.

Day 6 cancel: a member who wanted custom captions. Avery had not said not custom loudly enough on the page. Refunded, pointed them at a productized service, did not chase. Then added one line to the page: custom work is a separate package.

Recovery and the first stranger-to-stay sale

The first sale of this path is not the first join. It is three members who stay past month one. Five joined the first week. One canceled day 6. By day 45, three were still there. That matched the first-sale line. They were existing buyers, not cold ads. One of them had never opened the monthly email and still had the file in the vault. That is the design working.

On the first Tuesday of each month Avery spent two hours: rerun the core workflow on a real landscaping example, write what broke, drop a file named by month and job. Members who never opened the email still had the file.

Month 4: six workflows, two extra checklists, fourteen members, about \$126 a month. Enough to pay for the morning and to stop giving updates away in a messy inbox. A member asked for a live critique. Avery said no inside the \$9 and offered a one-time package at the freelance rate. The vault stayed a vault.

What Avery refused: a \$99 inner circle, a fake countdown, hiding the playbook, and a call schedule that would collapse the first week a job ran long.

Copy you can paste

Page hero

\$9 a month for updates the book does not get. New workflow when the tools change.
Cancel anytime.

Checkout line

\$9/month for updates the book does not get. Cancel anytime.

Post (only after buyers have joined)

The [file] is a one-time buy. This membership is the update layer: monthly workflow when the models change, new templates, cancel anytime. Built for people who already use the file.
\$9/month. Three files in the vault today.

DM to an existing buyer

You already have [file name]. The tools already moved. I am keeping a \$9 vault with the dated workflows the PDF cannot get. Three files are in there today, including [name the most useful one]. Cancel anytime. If I disappear, I refund the unused month. The original file stays yours either way.

Email 1 — invite to an existing buyer

You already have [file name]. The tools already moved. I am keeping a \$9 vault with the dated workflows the PDF cannot get. Three files are in there today, including [name the most useful one]. Cancel anytime. If I disappear, I refund the unused month. The original file stays yours either way.

Email 2 — monthly note

Subject: [Month] vault — what changed, what I added

What changed in the tools: [one paragraph, named model or setting].

What I added: [file name, job it does, where it sits].

What I am not doing this month: [a call / a new niche / custom reviews].

Good questions become next month's file. Custom work is a separate package.

Email 3 — after they buy the one-time file (once, not a popup on page one)

You have the [file]. If you want the living layer — dated workflows when the tools move, \$9/month, cancel anytime — it is here: [url]. The file you just bought stays yours either way.

Refund line

Cancel in two clicks from the billing portal. If I go quiet for 30 days without a note, email me and I refund the unused month. If you joined wanting custom work, I will refund this month and send the package link. I will not hide the button. I will not make you write an essay.

Vanish policy, on the page

Cancel in two clicks from the billing portal. If I go quiet for 30 days without a note, email me and I refund the unused month. I will not hide the button.

Week-by-week

This path does not start in week 1 of your business. It starts after the one-time file has sold.

Week 0 (gate)

Confirm you have buyers and a list of questions they already asked. If you do not, stop and go sell the file. Do not tour platforms. Do not name a community. The gate is real.

Week 1 — daily

Monday: three vault items outlined. Member page drafted. \$9. Vanish rule written.

Tuesday: files finished, named by job and date. Index written.

Wednesday: Stripe or Stan live. Buy from a second email. Cancel. Fix the trap if there is one.

Thursday: ten invite notes to existing buyers. No public thread. No Discord. No countdown.

Friday: send the ten. Point joins at the three files. Decline custom. Refund mistaken joins.

Saturday: if someone joined, make sure they can open the folder without emailing you. If they cannot, that is the only work.

Sunday: off. Do not add a call because the weekend felt quiet.

Week 2 — daily

Monday: point any new joins at the three files. Do not add a fourth yet unless a real question landed.

Tuesday–Thursday: day job, or the file still for sale. Mentions of the vault only to people who already have the file.

Friday: if someone asks for custom, decline inside the membership and name the other path. Put the reusable part of the question on a list for week 3's file.

Saturday–Sunday: off, or one sentence reply in the 48-hour window you already chose. Not a weekend desk.

Week 3

First monthly note even if it has only been three weeks — pick a cadence (first Tuesday) and hit it. Add one file that came from a real question. Same two headings: what changed, what I added. What I am not doing this month, if you need a third line to kill a rumor about calls.

Week 4

Look at cancels. If everyone left, the vault was a teaser. Fix the files before you invite more. If three stayed, you have a path. Count members, notes shipped (binary), files added (one is enough). Do not raise the price. Do not open Discord to save it.

Weeks 5–8. Same Tuesday. Same two headings. Keep selling the one-time file. Mention the vault as a second product, not a replacement. Cap if replies turn into unpaid consulting.

Month 3. Count members, stay-rate past day 45, and whether the vault would still be useful if you never hosted a call. If yes, keep \$9. If you now have six-plus dated workflows, you may test \$19 for new members and grandfather the first ones.

Quality bar

The bar: a member who never attends a call still got something they can run this month. If that is false, you are charging for a room.

Below the bar

A Discord that is dead, billed monthly. A welcome video and a roadmap. Update!! as a file name. Cancel buried in a form. The one-time file hidden. Custom captions delivered to one member and nobody else. A call they had to attend to get the prompt. A skipped note and a charge that still ran. Fake 12 spots. \$99 for three PDFs and a smile. Vibes in the monthly note (lots of exciting changes) instead of a named tool and a named break.

Above the bar

Three real files on day one, named by job and date. A monthly note that names tools, not vibes. The follow-up prompt started hedging; here is the blunt version beats lots of exciting changes. Cancel works without a performance. The one-time product remains for sale and remains true. A

48-hour window on weekdays. Custom deliverables get a no and a link to a package. Recap in the vault within 48 hours if a call happened. Vanish rule honored.

Five tests before you charge anyone

Sunday test. Open the vault with no calendar. Can a tired person run something tonight?

Name test. Every file is YYYY-MM-job. If you see Update!!, rename it.

Cancel test. Second email, two clicks, no ticket.

Sentence test. Can you say what members get that the book does not, in one breath?

February test. Will you still write the note on a tired Thursday? If no, do not open the door. A quarterly paid update pack is allowed instead.

Fail any one and you are not done. Keep building the folder. Do not collect \$9 on a fail.

What to measure

Week 1

One-time file has sold. Gate. If no, stop.

Invites sent to existing buyers. If this is zero, you launched to the void.

Three vault items live. Binary.

Cancel tested. Binary.

Joins from those invites. Five from twelve notes is a warm file.

Day 30

Members who had a chance to see the folder.

Day-7 cancels. A pile means the listing overpromised.

Monthly note shipped on time. A binary. Missed notes predict churn.

Files added. One is enough. Zero is a ghost charge.

Custom requests inside the \$9. If they rise, your copy is fuzzy or you are too available.

Revenue after refunds. Do not screenshot gross joins.

Day 90

Members who stay past month one. Three is a working vault. This is the first sale.

Day-45 stay-rate. Stayers divided by people who had a chance to be charged twice. Under 40% means the vault did not earn the second month.

Notes shipped on time across three months. Three of three, or you are slipping.

Files in the archive. Six-plus dated workflows is when \$19 for new members is even a conversation.

Cap hit or not. If you are doing custom to keep people, you already needed a cap.

Ignore

Discord online count. Likes on the announcement. Number of strangers who saw a public launch. Call attendance. Feelings about members who never log in. They paid for access, not for your feelings about engagement. They may log in the month something breaks. Measure stay-rate, not nag-rate.

One-line spreadsheet

Date joined, source (invite / file page / public), amount, cancel date if any, reason if they said it, notes shipped while they were a member (count), files added that month. Monthly tab: members, stay-rate past day 45, revenue after refunds, note shipped (yes/no). If a row is a join with no invite and no file purchase behind it, you launched to the void. Stop doing that.

Objections you will hear — including from yourself

The replies

I should charge \$99 so people take it seriously. People take files seriously. They take a \$99 empty room as a mistake. Earn \$9 first. Raise when the archive is fat.

I need a community for this to work. You need a vault. Ten quiet downloaders beat a hundred lurkers in a dead chat. If you want a group, that is a different path.

Buyers will be mad updates were not in the original file. Tell the truth: the file is the job as of a date. The vault is the living layer. You sold a complete file and you are offering a continuation.

Nobody wants another subscription. True for bad ones. False for \$9 that saves them from re-solving a broken prompt every time a model shifts. Easy cancel respects the fatigue.

I will launch this to grow my audience. Backwards. The audience of buyers already exists. A membership with no file behind it is a chat room with a card on file.

What if I cannot keep it up? Then do not open it. Or open it with the vanish rule already on the page. A clean refund is better than a silent charge.

I should include a Discord so it feels alive. Only if you will moderate it on a schedule and it is extra, not the product. Most \$9 vaults are better as a folder. Alive is a dated file, not a green dot.

Wait, did I already pay for this? The file is the job as of a date. This is the living layer. \$9. Cancel anytime. The original file stays yours either way.

I want you to review my captions every month. No inside the \$9. Here is the package. The reusable part of your question will show up as a file if it helps everyone.

Can I pause instead of cancel? If your tool has a pause, fine. Do not build a guilt maze. Cancel is enough. They can come back. The archive will still be there if you kept shipping.

What feeds this path

Upstream

The one-time file. New buyers are the only honest top of funnel. Mention the vault once after they have the file, not as a popup on page one.

You also need a job you still run. If you abandoned the system the file teaches, you cannot date a workflow. The membership is the dated version of what you already had to fix.

Buyer questions. Inbox, checkout comments, does this still work. Each repeated question is next month's file. If nobody asks anything, you may need a clearer file, not a membership.

What feeds the monthly note

Tool changes. Model updates, UI moves, a setting that used to be default. Keep a running log. The monthly note writes itself from that log.

Your own weekly work. A real example, rerun, what broke. Avery reran the landscaping workflow on a real example every first Tuesday. That is the note.

Downstream

A fatter archive. \$19 for new members, grandfathered \$9 for the first ones. A productized package for custom work that the vault keeps attracting. Seasonal one-time packs that also live in the vault. A playbook about the job, still for sale. Not a \$99 inner circle. Not a staffed community.

Printables or templates that started as a member file can become a \$9–\$19 one-time for non-members later. Members already have them. Do not yank files to resell them. Add, do not subtract.

What does not feed it

Cold ads to a \$9 vault. Affiliate blasts. Join the movement threads. Other people's mastermind screenshots. A public launch before the file has sold. Hiding the file to force the subscription. Those starve the only honest funnel: buyers who already trust you.

Mistakes

Ten-plus, and the recovery this week

Charging for a Discord that is dead. A quiet folder is a product. A quiet chat is a ghost town you billed. Recovery: turn the chat off or make it extra. Put this month's file in a folder with a name a Sunday person can find. Refund anyone who joined for the chat if the chat was the pitch.

Never updating. The charge continues. The vault does not. Recovery: ship a note this week even if it is late. If you skipped 30 days, refund the unused month without making them write an essay. Put the next note on a calendar.

Hiding the one-time product so you can milk a subscription. You starve the only source of members who already trust you. Recovery: put the file back on the site today. One line pointing at the vault as a second product.

Launching before the file has sold. You will pitch strangers a living layer on a book they never bought. Recovery: close signups. Go sell the file. Reopen when you have an invite list of buyers.

Making calls the product. They will miss the call. You will miss the call. Recovery: write the recap into the vault within 48 hours. Take calls off the page if you cannot keep them. The file is the product.

Fake scarcity. 12 spots on an infinite folder. People learn. Recovery: delete the counter. If you need a cap, use a real number you can host and close the door when you hit it.

Answering custom work inside \$9. You train members to treat the vault as a junior employee. Recovery: one no this week, one package link, one reusable question filed for next month. Add a line to the page: custom work is a separate package.

A guilt cancel. Two clicks. You earn the next month with files, not with friction. Recovery: test cancel from a second email today. If it takes a ticket, fix the trap before the next join.

A \$99 empty room. Recovery: drop to \$9 or close it. Refund the difference for the unused month. Fill three files before anyone new is charged.

Public circus in week 1. Recovery: stop the thread. Invite ten buyers instead. Ignore the stranger comments.

Skipping the February note because you are tired. That is the whole test. Recovery: skip the call if you listed one, write the file anyway. A short dated workflow beats a charming apology.

Removing people who never log in because it hurts your feelings. They paid for access. Recovery: leave them. Measure stay-rate, not nag-rate. They may log in the month something breaks.

Tools

The exact stack

Stripe subscriptions or Stan. One product, one price, one portal where they can cancel without emailing you a plea.

A simple member page. A logged-in folder, a locked Notion page, a Stan membership, a Circle space you actually update. The dumbest tool you will keep beats the pretty one you will abandon.

Dated file names. YYYY-MM-job. Searchable in six months.

Your existing email list of buyers. Not a new platform.

A calendar reminder for the monthly note. Same week, same two headings.

A running log of tool changes. A note file, not a feeling.

You do not need a mobile app, a points system, or a course platform. You do not need Zoom if you are not hosting.

Setup order

Confirm the file has sold. Write the sentence. Build three files in the tool you already write in. Then pick Stan or Stripe, not the reverse. Test buy. Test cancel. Then invites. If you already sold the file on Gumroad or Stan, use their membership add-on if cancel stays easy. Moving people to a new login in week 1 is a way to lose them before they see the three files.

What not to buy

A community platform you will not moderate. A mobile app. A points system. A course platform. Zoom if you are not hosting. A countdown app for fake scarcity. A second email tool. A CRM. A \$99/month community stack to collect \$9. Ads to a vault with no file behind it.

The \$0 path

A locked Google Drive or Notion page you already have, plus Stripe's free subscription on a Payment Link or Stan's free tier if you qualify, plus the email list of buyers you already have, plus

a calendar reminder. That is enough to charge \$9 and deliver three files this week. Paid community software waits until the vault is boring and full, which is the point, and even then you may never need it.

Checklist

- One-time file has sold to people who are not you
- You can name what members get that the file does not
- Gap list from the file and from real questions
- Three vault items live, named by job and date
- Two-line index: file, date, job
- Price \$9–\$19, default \$9
- Cancel tested from a second email
- Vanish/refund rule on the page
- Calls optional; vault useful either way
- No Discord required for the product
- No fake scarcity counter
- Existing buyers invited first, ten notes
- No public circus in week 1
- File remains for sale
- Checkout line matches the offer sentence
- Monthly note on the calendar, same week, same two headings
- One new useful file per month, even if short
- Custom asks declined inside the \$9
- General answers filed in the vault
- Cap ready if you cannot support more people
- Day 20: vault checked as a member would
- Day 45: stayers counted

Three past month one treated as the first real sale

Revenue counted after refunds

Self-test from the who section, honestly answered

February test passed (you will still write the note)

No \$99 empty room

No hiding the one-time product

FAQ

Do I need a membership if my file is selling?

Only if buyers still need something after they finish it — usually because tools move or seasons change. Do not invent a subscription to look like a real business. Default: if the same question shows up twice in your inbox, you need the vault. If it does not, you need a better file or a different path.

Can I launch the membership and the file on the same day?

You can. You should not. You will split your finish energy and have no honest invite list. Sell the file. Answer the follow-up questions. Then open the vault. Default: file first, vault after buyers exist.

What if I hate writing a monthly note?

Then do not open a membership. A quarterly bundle sold as a one-time update pack is allowed. Recurring billing is a promise. Default: skip this path, sell a dated update pack when the tools actually move.

Should I include a Discord?

Only if you will moderate it on a schedule and it is extra, not the product. Most \$9 vaults are better as a folder. Default: no Discord.

How do I handle a member who wants custom work?

Refund if they joined by mistake. Otherwise: no inside the membership, here is the package. Put the reusable part of their question in the vault. Default: refund the mistaken join, package link for the rest, one line added to the page.

What if the tools do not change that month?

Ship anyway. A seasonal file, a tighter SOP, a filled example you did not have in the book. Silence is the failure, not a quiet month in the industry. Default: one seasonal or tighter file, still a note with two headings.

Can I charge \$19 from day one?

If the vault already has a back catalog, yes. If it has three files, start at \$9. Grandfather early members when you raise. Default: \$9 until six dated workflows exist.

What counts as vanishing?

You skipped the monthly note and added no file, and 30 days passed. Charge still ran. Refund the unused month without making them write an essay. Default: 30 days, unused month, no speech.

How many members is too many at \$9?

When you cannot keep the note on time or you are doing custom work to keep people. For a folder-only vault, that number can be high. For a vault plus replies, it might be 30. Default: cap when the note slips or custom starts; 30 is a working number for replies.

Do I remove people who never log in?

No. They paid for access, not for your feelings about engagement. They may log in the month something breaks. Measure stay-rate, not nag-rate. Default: leave them.

What if I already have a community?

The vault is still the product. The chat is extra. If the community is the only value, you are on a different path and \$9 will not hold when the chat goes quiet. Default: folder first, chat optional, never reverse.

Can I use this to replace freelance?

Not at three members. Thirty at \$9 is \$270. That is a till, not a firm. Keep the productized package for custom work. Default: second till, after the file, beside freelance, not instead of it in month one.

Should I offer annual?

After monthly works. 10 months for the price of 12 is plenty. Do not discount monthly to fill seats. Default: monthly only until day-45 stay-rate is healthy.

What if a member forwards the files?

Watermark if you must. Write the license in one line. A \$9 vault will leak a little. Most churn is unused access, not theft. Default: one-line license, do not build DRM, keep shipping so staying is easier than stealing last month's note.

How do I mention this on the file's sales page?

One line, after the buy: optional living layer, \$9/month, cancel anytime. Not a popup. Not a bundle that hides the one-time price. Default: one sentence under the buy button, full pitch only in the post-purchase email.

What if I want to close it?

Honor the vanish rule. Refund unused month. Leave the archive up through the paid period. Do not ghost. A clean close is a reputation. A silent charge is a story they will tell. Default: one email, refund unused, door closed, file still for sale.